interlocked behind their backs, chins up and chests out, they were whispering to each other, passing judgmental stares at the likes of us.

‘Maybe this is what these training centres do,’ I added, ‘they teach them how to act like officers.’

‘Act? Or pretend?’ the south Indian girl commented.

‘You cannot pretend to be someone you’re not, whatever your training,’ I said.

‘Correct. And if I was the interviewer, I’d give them a negative ten for the colour of their T-shirts alone,’ she said, and both of us chuckled. Unlike me, she appeared jovial and happy.

‘But you cannot rule out the fact that someone might be genuine among them,’ I said, to which she rolled her eyes in disagreement.

‘By the way, I’m Gunjan. And I’m not from any institute.’

‘I’m Hema Rajkumar. And likewise.’ She extended her hand and I shook it. ‘Also, I’m starving. Are they going to give us food?’

‘Lunch has been arranged. It’s written in the joining instructions,’ I said. It was then that it dawned on me that after the lunch, the first test would be conducted. The feeble smile that Hema had managed to bring on my face vanished, along with the little hunger I had earlier felt. I had this feeling that I wasn’t prepared. If that wasn’t all, I now knew I would be competing against candidates from reputed training institutes.

The Indian Air Force personnel, a corporal and a sergeant, let us in after they checked our documents and allotted us a ‘chest number’ each—a number printed on a square piece of apron-like cloth that candidates would wear during tests. It was to be our only identity until the SSB interview concluded. I was allotted ‘Chest Number 04’. As we entered the gates, a squad of some thirty male candidates with similar chest numbers from another ongoing SSB interview in the same centre hurried past us. They hardly noticed us. The air inside the centre seemed intense, and it was eerily quiet, haunted by the ghosts of the thousands of dreams that had died here. But in some other places, like the vast garden in front of a white office building with sky-blue borders, the barracks and the ante room, and the small cafeteria next to an STD booth, the joy of recommendation lurked.